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How interdisciplinarity helps knowledge production: Reflections on a doctoral dissertation

Edina Ajanovic *, Beykan Çizel

Akdeniz University Faculty of Tourism, Dumlupinar Boulevard, 07070, Antalya, Turkey

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ABSTRACT

For the last several decades, there has been an ongoing discussion regarding disciplinary approaches towards the dissemination of theoretical/methodological frameworks and results that will enrich knowledge in the tourism field. However, there is still a lack of researchers' explanations and reflections regarding the benefits of involving into an interdisciplinary approach, which can lead to new forms of knowledge creation. Through this reflective study, the goal is to understand the process of writing and "being" the interdisciplinary PhD thesis writer in tourism, with interpretations referring to the elements of interdisciplinarity proposed in already existing tourism literature. By presenting the research process and results of the PhD thesis on persuasive communication occurring on online travel review platforms, the aim is to provide not only an interpretation of epistemology, but also of the ontology of conceptualizing and conducting tourism research in an interdisciplinary spirit and how this can stimulate further research on certain topic.

1. Introduction

Over the years, several critical analyses of epistemology and the nature of tourism studies, as well as how this tourism knowledge is used by academicians, have emerged (Coles, Hall, & Duval, 2006; Darbellay, 2016; Darbellay & Stock, 2012; Tribe, 1997, 2010). Hall (2005) sees the development of the discipline of tourism studies as a pragmatic issue regarding structure and resources that will advance research and knowledge, but also as a philosophical question of theoretical and empirical advancement. Due to the complex nature of tourism, there are several approaches to researching concepts, processes and behavioral patterns related to it, as well as multiple combinations of how to import knowledge from different disciplines into the field and disseminate new and unique frameworks. In this sense, multidisciplinary, interdisciplinary, transdisciplinary (Darbellay & Stock, 2012; Darbellay, 2016), extra-disciplinary (Tribe, 1997), and post-disciplinary (Coles et al., 2006) approaches can be differentiated.

The indisciplinity of tourism studies (Tribe, 1997) is, as I believe, what makes it an important phenomenon to contemplate and reflect on, either from a professional, academic and/or educational perspective. Despite years of disciplinarity discussion, a significant number of tourism studies lack author reflections regarding the benefits of involving into multi- and/or interdisciplinary approaches and elaboration on how this may improve the initial ideas, as well as the potential for previously obtained results to inform the derivation of new (inter-, trans- or post-disciplinary) frameworks and knowledge. Moreover, a recent study shows that tourism scholars still face some difficulties in differentiating between multi- and interdisciplinary approaches (Okumus, van Niekerk, Koseoglu &

* Corresponding author.
E-mail addresses: edinaajanovic@akdeniz.edu.tr (E. Ajanovic), beykan@akdeniz.edu.tr (B. Çizel).

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Bilgihan, 2018). Since tourism studies require greater epistemological breadth, doctoral theses can be considered as the appropriate form of academic material to elaborate on it, while reflective papers of PhD students and holders on their disciplinary journeys during or after their postgraduate education in tourism represent valuable accounts. Through authors' retrospective reflections of the PhD writing process, it may be shown how "knowing through practice" in this context is applied.

In this study, I am taking the philosophical hermeneutics as the epistemological stance (Schwandt, 2000) to reflect on (Ateljevic, Harris, Wilson, & Collins, 2005) and make sense of the concept of interdisciplinarity in conducting PhD research in tourism. I will try to "illuminate" the process of writing interdisciplinary thesis in tourism field by explaining the purpose of writing one, the activities that are involved, the significance of the process, and its outcomes (Cerbone, 2006). The interpretations I make are based on the writings of a collection of journal articles addressing disciplinarity issues in tourism, my own lived experiences as a PhD student and a single researcher in interdisciplinary thesis on persuasive communication occurring on online review platforms. In this way, I am attempting to find an answer to epistemological questions of "*how*" the knowledge in my PhD thesis was created and the outcomes of it, while also attempting to reflect on the ontological question of *"being"* an interdisciplinary thesis writer in the tourism field.

In the first section, I offer a brief overview of disciplinary debates regarding tourism knowledge production in the current literature, with specific emphasis on interdisciplinary approaches, followed by a review of how studies in higher education on tourism are involved and contribute to the disciplinary issues of the field. After presenting a positionality statement and describing my hermeneutical journey in deriving interpretations, I continue with elaborations on the process of building an interdisciplinary framework, its outcomes, and my reflections on the question of "being" an interdisciplinary PhD thesis writer in tourism. Finally, I conclude the paper with a discussion on this journey and what benefits it may have for the broader academic tourism audience.

2. Literature review

2.1. Disciplinary debates in tourism studies

In the late 1980s and throughout the whole 1990s, the continuous discussion concerning various approaches to knowledge creation in tourism studies divided the interested scholars. On one side, there were those whose opinion was that tourism should be studied as a distinct discipline. Thus, Leiper (1981) coined the term "tourology" on the basis of his general tourism theory as a system, while Jovicic (1988), who claimed the non-existence of a discipline that could encompass the whole complexity of the phenomena, proposed "tourismology" as the distinct science of tourism. In their study, Echtner and Jamal (1997) provided an extensive list of scholars who agreed upon a lack of an integrated framework and content in tourism, whilst simultaneously believing it could not be seen as a distinct discipline. Further contemplation on the topic of disciplinarity in tourism research was induced by Jafari (1990), who recommended the development of a cross-disciplinary knowledge-based platform with scientific foundations. This call soon resulted in the emergence of studies that contemplated on the "disciplinary dilemma of tourism studies" and challenged its disciplinary status (Echtner & Jamal, 1997; Tribe, 1997).

Most of the contemporary papers on the disciplinarity of tourism studies start with definitions of several disciplinarity concepts. Accordingly, Darbellay (2016) derived definitions of disciplinarity itself, and also multi-, inter-and transdisciplinarity, which differ by position of the researchers towards the researched topic, degree of openness, integration and interaction with other disciplines. Based on these criteria, he derived main characteristics and outcomes of different disciplinary approaches. On the lowest level of disciplines' openness and interaction continuum stands disciplinarity, where researchers work on topics via methodological approaches, precisely defined inside the discipline itself. On the moderate level of openness and interaction are the concepts of multi- and interdisciplinarity, each being equally far from the center of the continuum, but in opposite directions. Multidisciplinarity assumes that researchers from different disciplines, each from their perspective, deal with a certain topic (theoretical and/or practical problems) without establishing any real interaction between each other. Interdisciplinarity, in contrast, benefits from interaction, interface, exchange, shared research topic interest and interdependence in conducting research in the field of tourism. In interdisciplinarity, this dynamic interaction between two or more disciplines, through borrowing or transferring the concept from one field to another, is used in order to describe, analyze, and understand the complexity of a phenomenon (Darbellay & Stock, 2012, p. 453). Finally, transdisciplinarity is characterized by a high level of openness and interaction, where researchers work to develop a conceptual and methodological framework that goes beyond the disciplinary boundaries in order to resolve a concrete problem between science and society.

In the context of tourism, intradisciplinary perspectives on methodological and philosophical conflicts within disciplines "housing" tourism studies contributed to further discussions on disciplinarity issues (Echtner & Jamal, 1997). As noted by Graburn and Jafari (1991), no single discipline can accommodate, treat, or understand tourism; it can be studied only by crossing disciplinary boundaries towards searching and forming multidisciplinary perspectives. The disciplinary status of tourism was tested based on a set of criteria proposed in the literature on the philosophy of science and sociology of knowledge (Echtner & Jamal, 1997). Accordingly, Tribe (1997) argued that tourism should be approached as an area consisting of two overlapping fields: tourism business studies (TF1) and non-business tourism studies (TF2) (p. 649). He also explained the creation of tourism knowledge in the form of embedded circles, where the outer circle represents disciplines and sub-disciplines, the middle one represents the field of tourism (TF1+TF2), and the inner circle represents the world of tourism. Between the outer and middle circle, Tribe input the band K to demonstrate developments and knowledge creation in the field of tourism. According to Tribe (2004), knowledge in tourism is either produced within the disciplinary context or it emerges from the context of application outside the disciplinary boundaries and with its own distinct theories, methods, and practices. Looking from a tourism perspective, multidisciplinarity represents the interface between one particular discipline and field of tourism, while interdisciplinarity assumes several disciplines to interact with one another and the field of tourism. Gibbons et al. (1994) proposed two modes of knowledge production: Mode 1 encompasses multi- and interdisciplinarity

approaches and is dominant in higher education (Tribe, 2004) and Mode 2, labeled as transdisciplinarity, functions within the external world. Instead of transdisciplinarity, Tribe (1997) uses the term "extra-disciplinarity", as this mode of knowledge is produced in the context of application in the world of tourism, where solutions for the problems are searched for outside of disciplinary boundaries. By combining the writings of Darbellay (2016) and Tribe (1997) on disciplinary approaches to knowledge creation in tourism following figure was derived (Fig. 1).

Coles et al. (2006) agree on the notion that it is problematic to see tourism studies as an academic discipline in its own right because of the intellectual and institutional backgrounds of the scholars (p.302). In addition to the above approaches, these authors propose post-disciplinary perspective for ideas and connections to be logically concluded without being limited by "artificial" disciplinary boundaries. In trying to encompass all definitions of disciplinarity concepts, Darbellay (2016) offered two explanations of post-disciplinarity. The first one is about adopting an epistemological position that makes it possible to go beyond disciplinary boundaries, where the idea of "crossing" and associating different and complementary perspectives is emphasized (Darbellay, 2016, p. 367). The second one calls for the pure disappearance of disciplines so that space for intellectual freedom and creativity may emerge. Instead of considering only the interaction and integration aspects, it emphasizes the importance of an epistemological position that allows a researcher to think outside of the box and rethink the disciplinary organization of knowledge. Other researchers interpret post-disciplinary as "… quests for plural knowability—especially appropriate where external assumptions or imposed truths have squashed or denied (intentionally or unintentionally) other/local/Indigenous mandates of knowing" (Hollinshead, 2016, p. 350). Approaching tourism research in this manner will aim to identify new conditions and forms of tourism, allow the emergence of new modes of analysis and theories, and rethink some of the established tourism-related concerns of the past (Coles et al., 2006, p. 311).

Parallel with the ongoing discussions on disciplinary perspectives of tourism epistemology, questions of paradigm in tourism research have also emerged. The trialogue on the nature and consequences of the paradigms in tourism research by Tribe, Dann, and Jamal (2015) is a good example of this. In his part of the paper, Tribe concluded that there was no revolution that caused change to his proposed model of a tourism knowledge system assuming indisciplinarity. Meanwhile, Jamal proposed a counter view to this statement, assuming that neoliberalism as a broader societal paradigm and sustainable tourism are exemplars of paradigms in a narrow sense, at which level scientific revolution can start. In his final viewpoint, Dann referred to Cohen's (1979) notion that it is pointless to search for one particular theoretical approach to the study of tourism and that a pluralistic and eclectic research strategy is more appropriate. Theory-driven tourism research should benefit from selectively abstracting the most useful content from a variety of compatible theories, which will allow the development of cumulative insights towards a better understanding of tourism phenomena (Dann & Cohen, 1991). Echtner and Jamal (1997) emphasized that theoretical diversity is what makes the study of tourism rich, but complicated. A "broad, paradigmatic" umbrella could guide and facilitate the accumulation of a cohesive body of knowledge in tourism, but there should be no intention of creating one philosophical approach. Rather, it should be accepted that different research problems may require different philosophical approaches (Echtner & Jamal, 1997, p. 879). Starting with the previous idea of a linguistic approach to knowledge development in tourism studies (Belhassen & Caton, 2009), as a human understanding of the world is based on use of language, Caton (2016) philosophically explored the potential for and value of imagining a humanist paradigm for tourism studies.

To sum it up, in his "dedisciplination" of tourism studies, Darbellay (2016) voluntarily decided not to confront and create rupture between inter-, trans- and post-disciplinarity in tourism studies, but to benefit from the transformative potential of these concepts. Accordingly, researchers should not give up disciplinarity, but should be encouraged to permanently self-reflect on the nature of disciplines, their boundaries, and their links to other related or more distant disciplines (Darbellay, 2016, p. 367).

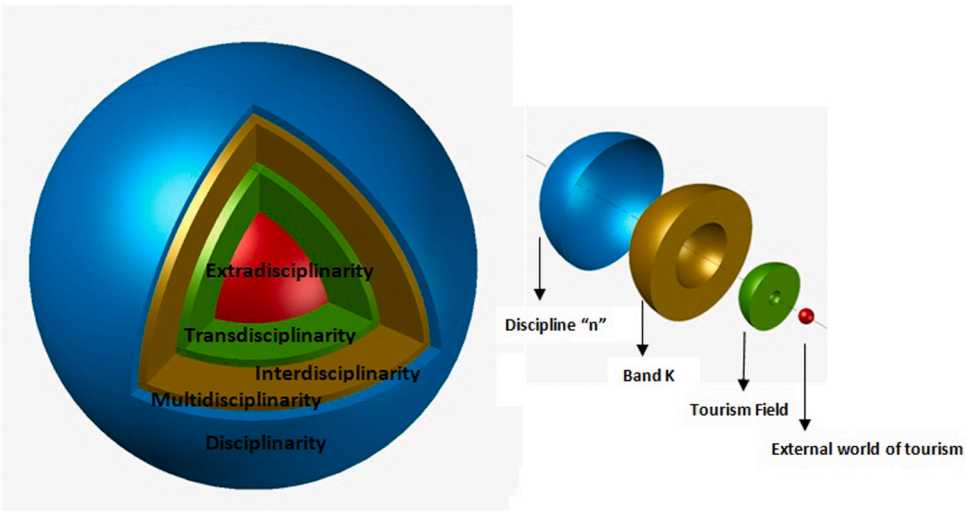

Fig. 1. Disciplinary approaches to knowledge creation in tourism.

2.2. Interdisciplinarity in tourism research

Interdisciplinarity may be seen as the process where researcher goes beyond the borders of his/her own disciplines, but also returns to it, finalizing the circle that has the potential to introduce the notion of post-disciplinarity (Coles et al., 2006). This approach is not concerned with abandoning disciplines, but instead requires awareness of their limitations and alternatives in order to use all scholar possibilities to produce more meaningful and comprehensive knowledge of the field. According to Echtner and Jamal (1997), the interdisciplinary nature of tourism should be seen as an opportunity for dialogue, debate and interpretation towards a deeper understanding of the researched phenomena. They argue that interdisciplinarity involves working between disciplines and blending various philosophies and techniques so that particular disciplines do not stand apart, but are brought together intentionally and explicitly to seek a synthesis (p.878–879). Therefore, it can be concluded that, once adopted and embraced, an interdisciplinary approach potentially allows the researcher to attain the necessary awareness and understandings of other dimensions and aspects from which knowledge can come from. Skills developed through applying interdisciplinary research can be useful in potential future attempts to use the full potential of trans-, extra-, or post-disciplinary approaches towards "complete openness" in knowledge creation, which is often cited in the recent tourism disciplinary literature.

Considering the points discussed above, special attention should be given to the interdisciplinary aspects of the research, the characteristics, the processes and the outcomes that this approach can bring. The importance of it was emphasized in the study by Darbellay and Stock (2012), who analyzed tourism as a complex interdisciplinary research object. They highlighted the necessity "to explore the advantages and limits of interdisciplinary theoretical frameworks, methodologies and research techniques in order to understand how society's touristic dimensions are constructed and reconstructed at the level of the industry, the practices, the place, the governance, as well as the politics and policies" (p.452). Thus, an interdisciplinary approach is not only necessary when a solution for a specific problem is needed, but also when theoretical frameworks from other disciplines need improvement or more meaningful application in order to obtain a better understanding of some tourism concepts and/or build a foundation for new research on the related topic.

When talking about the interdisciplinarity of tourism research, Darbellay and Stock (2012) refer to three important features:

a) mediation between different perspectives in order to better organize the co-production of knowledge on a phenomenon that is hard to be explained from only one perspective;
b) capitalizing on different disciplinary bodies of knowledge in order to more adequately understand the complexity of tourism;
c) hybridization through the circulation of concepts and practices.

In one of the more recent studies, Okumus, van Niekerk, Koseoglu, and Bilgihan (2018) aimed to investigate meanings, enablers and barriers to interdisciplinary research from the perspective of tourism scholars. Results showed that more than 50% of 356 participants coming from 193 different countries and 182 higher education institutions perceived multidisciplinarity and interdisciplinarity as exactly the same, very similar or somewhat similar. Moreover, many participants could not accurately indicate what interdisciplinarity is and how it differs from multidisciplinarity. Most of the attempts at forming definitions were focused on collaborative aspects rather than output; in other words, emphasis was placed on the process rather than the type of knowledge that emerges. Regarding barriers to interdisciplinary tourism research, Okumus et al. (2018) identified several factors, including strong identification with the discipline, hesitation to go beyond the comfort-zone, difficulties due to different research philosophies, and the rejection of grants for this kind of research. Contrarily, "enablers" are the encouragements by the funding agencies or the institution that urge a researcher to deal with specific topics and established research networks. Authors have proposed changes in course requirements and mentor's guidance as important aspects of making PhD students more exposed to new fields and methodologies. In addition, journal editors and reviewers are advised to encourage authors to refer more to the nature of the knowledge basis of their research or the level of involvement of multiple disciplines.

At this point, we may see that there is a firm ground for disciplinary debates regarding knowledge production in tourism studies, as well as clearly positioned benefits of involving in interdisciplinary research in this field. However, misunderstandings of the disciplinarity concepts are still evident among the broader academic tourism community. Education in tourism is considered to be one of the key areas that can meaningfully contribute to better understandings of and reflection on the nature of tourism studies. PhD candidates are especially seen as catalysts of new knowledge production in the field, implying the importance of their reflective studies on issues of tourism epistemology.

2.3. Reflective research in tourism higher education

Tourism education and training, as the third dimension of the concept of tourism after the phenomenon of tourism in the external world and the study of tourism (Tribe, 1997), can be considered as an important element and factor in raising awareness and creating a basis for involvement in interdisciplinary research. Considering the disciplinarity issues presented above, as well as examination of disciplines that inform PhD research (Weiler, Moyle, & McLennan, 2012) and epistemological/philosophical reflections in tourism education (Tribe 2001, 2002), changes have been evident since Pearce's (1993) call for tourism educators to not deliver core principles, facts, and methods to students. Furthermore, there is an ongoing call for more transformative views and approaches in the field of tourism education, such as experiential learning (Liang, Caton, & Hill, 2015), which will expand the perspective of what education can achieve and how it does so (Walker & NgaraManyamba, 2020; Young, Witsel, & Boyle, 2017).

The process of writing a PhD thesis is, by its essence, a transformative process on a personal, academic, professional, and existential

level. Many aspects of this process were addressed in existing literature, including how to cope with stress (Devonport & Lane, 2014), identifying a great thesis, dissertation topics, questions regarding leisure studies, and exploring mentoring strategies to help students (Duffy, Pinckney, Powell, Bixler, & McGuire, 2018), in addition to the numerous reflexive studies on PhD journeys from various perspectives (Belhassen, 2012; Pike, 2003; Zahra & Ryan, 2005). Reflexivity is valuable, as it provides the production of more open and collaborative tourism knowledge (Ateljevic et al., 2005, p. 19). Alvesson and Sköldberg (2000) define it as "the complex relationship between processes of knowledge production and the various contexts of such processes, as well as the involvement of the knowledge producer" (p. 5).

PhD theses are used as accounts to be reflected on in light of several factors: extending understandings of the application of certain theories in tourism knowledge production (Ren, Pritchard, & Morgan, 2010), illustrating the use of theologically reductionist analysis by emphasizing philosophical reflection on theoretical assumptions, realizing the importance of language and pre-understandings (Belhassen, 2012), and reflecting on the evolution of one's own thinking throughout their PhD journey and distinguish between academia and industry (Pike, 2003). While Ren et al. (2010) considered PhD research as a "key space for the creation of 'new' knowledge" (p.892) during the examination of their process of researching as tourism scholars, Belhassen (2012) provided an example of how a researcher's religious reflectivity can advance their understanding of and relations to religious phenomena and participants under study. From the perspective of a former practitioner in the industry who turned to academia, Pike (2003) sees writing a PhD as a process of learning and evaluating the research process. He emphasized personal changes from a "booster"—someone who sees tourism development as inherently good and beneficial, to an individual with a more "holistic view" of tourism, in line with societal marketing philosophy.

In addition to these experiential accounts, Zahra & Ryan, 2005 reflected on the complexities of the research process in the context of RTOs by approaching tourism as a multi-paradigmatic phenomenon. They emphasized that researchers should understand the human nature, ontology, epistemology, and methodology assumed by certain paradigm. After analyzing each paradigm suitable for the context in which their research took place, authors proposed multi-pragmatic and bricoleur methodological approaches that could facilitate the investigation of complex tourism-related phenomena. Although more than a decade old, it seems that this reflective paper is still relevant today, considering the similar discussions regarding paradigms in tourism research presented earlier. As stated by Tribe et al. (2015), "the study of paradigms reveals that knowledge is rarely settled once and for all. It is nearly always in a process of becoming." (p.28). This is further proof that reflective studies are important— especially those on PhD research processes or on epistemological/ontological stances and methodologies adopted to inform and enrich the understanding of knowledge production in tourism, which is both complex and multifaceted.

In addition to papers discussing post-disciplinarity on epistemological, methodological and practical levels, there are inspiring papers that regard it as a personal philosophical stance (Pernecky, Munar, & Wheeller, 2016). Here, several "post-disciplinary-minded tourism researchers", or researchers as "disciplinary tourists" (Munar, Pernecky, & Feighery, 2016:p. 346), reflected on their journeys, during which they dealt with interdisciplinary research, eventually being drawn to the post-disciplinary mind-set.

Graduate students and their training programs are seen as central in increasing the interdisciplinary research capacity in order to face the most critical technological and socio-technological challenges (Borrego & Newswander, 2010). Some of the literature of higher education deals with questions of identifying learning outcomes, methods for evaluating interdisciplinary graduate programs, and students' learning performance (Borrego & Newswander, 2010). It also deals with "essential tensions'' reflected in affect, epistemologies and structural tensions among interdisciplinary scholarships in environment–society research centers (Turner, Benessaiah, Warren, & Iwaniec, 2015). After comparing the interdisciplinary studies in humanities literature with proposals in science and engineering, Borrego and Newswander (2010) identified disciplinary grounding, communication, and integration as common categories of learning outcomes for interdisciplinary graduate education. The aspect they diversified is the operationalization of integration - through teamwork in science and engineering and critical awareness in the humanities. In order to successfully navigate the essential tensions in interdisciplinary scholarship, Turner et al. (2015) recommended leaders of interdisciplinary research centers to adopt process-oriented and self-reflective management of the unique epistemic culture of their centers.

Despite evolving disciplinarity discussions regarding tourism studies, with the continuous opening of new dimensions and developments in shaping, practicing, studying, and teaching tourism, it is hard to articulate and conduct interdisciplinary studies and PhD theses in this field. Thus, it can be concluded that the similar issues related to learning outcomes, methods, and challenges reported in the broad interdisciplinary scholarship can be applicable to the tourism field as well. In addition, besides further research and discussions regarding how to manage interdisciplinary teams in tourism, it is also important to focus on reflections of interdisciplinary theses in the tourism field, as there is a lack of criteria on how to conduct and evaluate research in this spirit, as well as what the prerequisite for a person that is supposed to do it is. In light of this, I offer reflections on my own PhD journey, providing interpretations of epistemological concerns related to *how* the process of interdisciplinary thesis writing occurred and what are its outcomes, as well as my answer to ontological questions of "*being*" an interdisciplinary thesis writer in tourism.

2.3.1. Case thesis, positionality statement, and hermeneutical approach

My reflections and interpretations on interdisciplinarity in tourism research are based on PhD research in Tourism Management that I conducted in Turkey as an international student. The goal of my thesis was to conduct a more comprehensive investigation into the persuasiveness of online hotel review platforms through the examination of structure, characteristics, and functions of the attitudes expressed in guests' reviews, as well as persuasive cues in hotelier's responses to these. Throughout the whole research process, I combined knowledge from various fields: tourism literature regarding the effects and structures of online reviews and their management, social psychology, computer science, nursing studies, ethnographic studies, and online marketing research.

My PhD supervisor played a vital role in raising my awareness and encouraging me to fully embrace the interdisciplinary approach.

As a professor with more than 23 years of teaching experience, with majors in tourism and a PhD in business administration, he believed that I should dive into other disciplines and explore the use of the frameworks that would best inform my research topic while using my previous work experience as a travel agent in Serbia and consultant for a software company in the tourism sector in Turkey. Besides the aforementioned, my interpretations made in the thesis were based on my knowledge of the tourism field that I had gained throughout my vocational, graduate, and master education in Serbia and the PhD I pursued in Turkey. Finally, in the middle of my PhD, I also started teaching tourism management to undergraduate students.

During my secondary education, I was taught to look at tourism as a multidisciplinary and complex phenomena and that, in order to properly understand and manage its multiple elements, I had to possess knowledge from several disciplines. While I was writing my thesis, I read a couple of papers on disciplinarity issues related to tourism studies; however, it was only after finishing the work on my thesis that I started to read about it in more detail. This started a new hermeneutical circle for me, as I became able to reflect on my thesis in light of the disciplinarity issues raised in the literature. This circling between the whole (disciplinarity issues in tourism) and the part (my thesis) was constant with each new paper I read. I also started to include reflexive papers of other PhD journeys in tourism studies, as well as papers discussing disciplinarity and paradigm debates in tourism education. Parallel with these, the academic activities that followed my thesis completion, such as presenting a summary at the postgraduate student conference and publishing the thesis results, were added to my previous experience. All these activities induced multiple new contemplating processes, which challenged but also encouraged me to reflect on and interpret the process and outcome of writing an interdisciplinary PhD thesis in tourism and question "being" someone involved in this process.

By following the view of interdisciplinary nature of tourism as an opportunity for dialogue, debate, and interpretation towards deeper understandings of the researched phenomena (Echtner & Jamal, 1997), I used a hermeneutical approach, one of the four elements of reflective research (Alvesson & Sköldberg, 2000), to reflect on my PhD journey. Hermeneutics refers to a set of skills used to challenge oneself to find out how to compare and understand concepts under study (Bernstein, 1991), which makes it a suitable approach in trying to understand the phenomenon of writing theses in an interdisciplinary manner.

The subject of the current reflective paper is my PhD thesis, which centered around online travel review platforms, and experiences of writing such work in an interdisciplinary spirit. It is hermeneutical because it relies on the language, understanding, and interpretations that were used both in the thesis under study and the understanding of the disciplinary debates in the tourism field. The interpretations are based on my emic perspective as a past PhD thesis writer. I was entering a dialectical process between distance and familiarity, contemplating what I knew about tourism phenomena, my level of awareness of its disciplinarity issues, scopes of the discussion, and new horizons that were opening for the field. I contemplated my relations with this debate, challenging what previous educational, professional, and academic experience had brought to me, how academic work I produced was in accordance with it, and to what extent I fit into the role of the future tourism scholar or practitioner. I combined these interpretations with those of my thesis supervisor, whose views were vital, both during the thesis writing process and in the process of reflecting and understanding its

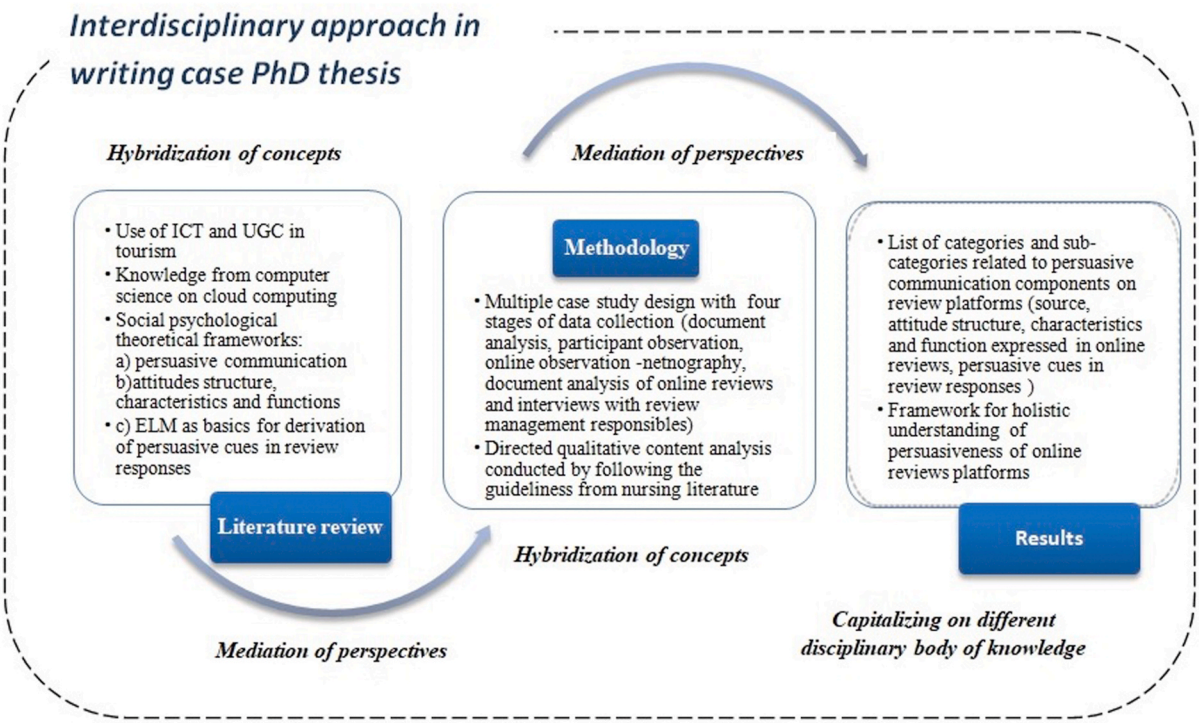

Fig. 2. Interdisciplinary approach in writing case PhD thesis.

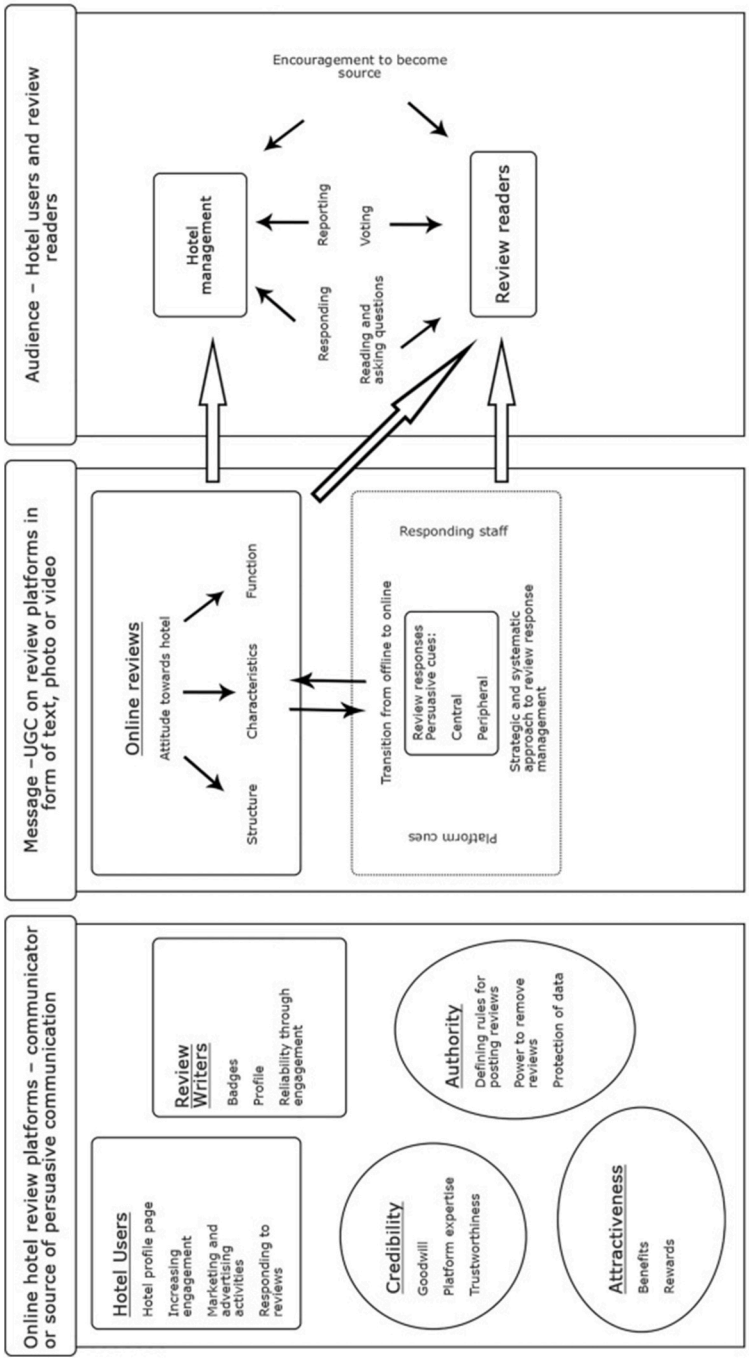

Fig. 3. Model of persuasive communication on online hotel review platforms (Ajanovic & Çizel, 2020).

interdisciplinarity—the essence of this phenomenon, the context and interpretations. As a result of this hermeneutical process, I grouped interpretations into three categories: building an interdisciplinary research framework, the outcome of the interdisciplinary research process, and "being" an interdisciplinary thesis writer in tourism.

2.3.2. Building an interdisciplinary research framework

By incorporating conceptual propositions of interdisciplinarity in tourism studies into my current reflective study, the process and outcome of my thesis on the persuasiveness of online travel review platforms is illustrated in Fig. 2.

Work on conceptualizing the interdisciplinary research framework of my thesis started with reading in-depth explanations from computer sciences on revolutionary aspects of Web 2.0 technology, emphasizing the structural characteristics and functioning of social media channels. With the people-centric turn in Internet technology, people are able to generate their own content and express themselves in a new online social forum, with travel reviews being one of the most popular and powerful online content in tourism. After I took several courses throughout the first two years of my PhD (such as tourism marketing, tourism planning policy, organizational theory, and social psychology) and considering my previous professional experiences, I revolved my thesis proposal around the goal of understanding the nature of the communication on online review platforms. However, as I progressed through my readings on social psychology, while simultaneously following the ever-growing number of studies and accumulating knowledge on online travel review platforms (see Ajanovic & Çizel, 2020 for all the references related to the case thesis), puzzles of the theoretical framework on persuasive communication (Aronson, Wilson, Akert, & Sommers, 2013; Hovland, Janis, & Kelley, 1953), which were divided into sections devoted to attitude research, structure, characteristics, function, and cues (Aronson et al., 2013; Eagly & Chaiken, 1993; Petty & Cacioppo, 1986), started to fit in. In order to better deconstruct and understand this process, I adopted a qualitative research approach influenced by those used in nursing studies (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005). Personally, I find significant similarities between nursing- and tourism-related qualitative research, as each is interested in the context of an individual's experiences with the phenomena under investigation. As a nursing professional should listen to patient's experiences regarding new drugs or treatments and follow their progress in order to assure a better quality of life, a travel practitioner should similarly refer to a client's travelling experiences, lifestyle, and leisure patterns in order to offer the most optimized travel product. An interdisciplinary framework and reflections on qualitative research have informed a four-stage data collection process: 1) document analysis of online available materials for review platforms, such as online travel agencies (OTAs) and meta-search engines, regarding their business activities and features, 2) participant (offline) observation in a consulting company, which was official representative of two large meta-search engine companies, and netnographic (online) observation of one worldwide known meta-search review platform; 3) document analysis of online reviews and management responses from three chosen 5-star resort hotels on one national and international meta-search engine and one international OTA over a 2-year period; and 4) interviews with participants responsible for hotel review management. As the result of the analysis process, a whole set of categories, sub-categories and context descriptions of the studied phenomena and, eventually, new model of persuasive communication on online review platforms were derived.

2.3.3. Outcome of the interdisciplinary research process

The thesis results showed that factors of persuasive communication proposed by the Yale approach (Hovland et al., 1953), such as source, communicator, message and audience, are evident in the context of online review platforms as well. However, by employing an interdisciplinary approach in this context, I derived a comprehensive framework explaining functional patterns of hotel review platforms, where users can express themselves and create their own micro communicational units whilst also strengthening the platform's own communicational mechanisms and elements on a macro level (Fig. 3). Communication factors are grouped under three main elements. First is the online review platform as a communicator or source of communication itself, with hotel users and review writers as its sub-sources and related characteristics. Second, message components include both online reviews in text form and management responses to such reviews. Reviews can be observed in terms of attitudes' structure, characteristics, and function, with each one of these aspects being deconstructed in more detail, while hotel review responses are deconstructed in terms of central and peripheral cues. The final component of the proposed model is audience, consisting of the hotel properties, towards which the reviews are directed, and the broader audience of review readers.

The deconstruction of the communication source proposed in the case thesis raises new questions in terms of what the factors of a successful travel review platform are and how this is perceived by platform users, and showcases new perspectives on the concept of trust in virtual communities. Following this framework, the question "Whom should people trust on these platforms?" emerges. Should they trust reviewers because they can relate to structure, characteristics, and/or the functions of attitudes expressed in their reviews? Or hotel management that provides sincere descriptions and visuals of its property and responds to reviews with content that is respectful, creative, and contains high-quality arguments? Should they trust the fairness of the mutual communication between the reviewer and the property, or in rankings of the hotel properties and number of reviews found? Or the platform, its expertise, authority, credibility, and goodwill in providing alternative spaces for people to use them in the pre-purchase stage? Should each of these aspects be researched separately or cumulatively, and is there any sequential order of their effects? Current studies on review platforms have asked some of these questions one by one, but should we ask them all at once? Finally, the results of the current thesis may be used in future research regarding interactions between humans and technology, which is also at the center of new forms of tourism, such as smart tourism or smart tourism destinations.

2.3.4. "Being" an interdisciplinary researcher in tourism

The question of "being" an interdisciplinary thesis writer in tourism was actually not present when I started my PhD course. This whole process was not only about the evolution of the topic, initial framework, and results, but also of my personal progress and

growth. During and after my PhD, I continuously read papers on the philosophy of science—particularly disciplinary issues in tourism—which raised new ontological and epistemological questions regarding the knowledge of tourism studies. This debate was the initial inspiration for me to take a reflective look at my thesis. According to my interpretation, interdisciplinary PhD writers in tourism do not simply combine theoretical frameworks from different disciplines and try to fit them into the context under investigation. Rather, they consider all the fore structures of relevant concepts and various pre-understandings surrounding the studied phenomena (Pernecky & Jamal, 2010). While reflecting on and interpreting my thesis, I used an entire set of fore structures: my previous education in tourism, professional experience, knowledge from several disciplines informing the tourism field and qualitative research, and tourism disciplinary debate outcomes and propositions. In addition, iteration, abstraction and interpretation, which are typical for engagement with data obtained through qualitative research methods, are also characteristic of the whole process of writing an interdisciplinary PhD thesis. This is, as I see it, a constant evaluative process, continuing even after the thesis is finished.

Not only does each discipline master its own paradigm methods and views of tourism, but there is also what Tribe (1997) describes as knowledge "that comes from the sector itself". Being a PhD student or scholar in tourism implies a necessity to deal with ontological issues and reflect on disciplinarity issues of tourism, as well as on previous professional experiences in the field, which may also differ depending on whether one is involved in tourism in the demand-generating region or at the destination. By having professional experience in a business setting in both emitting and receptive tourism countries, my knowledge came from management and marketing disciplines; however, the in-depth understanding of the phenomenon I examined in the thesis came from the body of knowledge of social psychology and computer sciences. This interdisciplinary view on tourism studies, especially on practicing, studying and doing research in it, is what brings a more holistic view and understanding of the phenomena under investigation. However, this same view assisted me in coining what I describe as a "loop" in my relation to tourism and its studies. Just as I thought I had mastered it, I get caught inside its complexity, which forces me to reconstruct my own body of knowledge and perspective on it again. The first loop occurred after I finished my vocational education and started working for a travel agency. My practical insights made me change my views that I had learned in school, resulting in me deciding to study tourism at university. The second loop occurred after I had finished my master in tourism and decided to pursue my PhD in another country at a well-known tourism center. Doing my PhD was a loop in itself, as it changed my understandings of studying, conducting research, and teaching tourism. This reflective study on disciplinary issues, the dissemination of knowledge in tourism, and the position and role of someone who calls himself/herself a scholar in tourism is probably the beginning (or end?) of another loop in my case.

While I was a PhD student, and now as a holder of this degree, I am aware of my thesis supervisor as a key figure and reference in the whole PhD process. During the thesis writing process, I had regular consultancies with my supervisor, during which we had a series of discussions regarding how to build a solid conceptual and theoretical framework and conduct systematical data collection and analysis. There was also a series of doubts, dilemmas, and positions regarding concept–concept, student–concept, supervisor–concept, student–supervisor, and, at the very end of the PhD process, student–thesis jury. Throughout the whole process, which took several years, the help, guidance and support of my supervisor were of enormous value.

3. Discussion and conclusion

Not being characterized as a discipline but rather a field is what makes tourism an even more complex phenomenon, as various types of disciplinary approaches and paradigms are employed in trying to provide explanations for understanding it. Therefore, the pluralism of reflections on the research process from different disciplinary and philosophical stances is what may help us to grasp the most complex ideas of tourism as a field and phenomena. By presenting a research process of a thesis on communication on travel review platforms, my goal was to show the process and benefits of the intersectionality of several disciplines. My reflections and evaluations of this process were in line with the perspectives of interdisciplinarity proposed by Darbellay and Stock (2012). Mediation between different perspectives in order to better organize the co-production of knowledge on a researched topic is evident in both the literature review and methodological part of the thesis. Throughout the multiple-stage data collection process, the knowledge gained from one step was often used as a basis for the next. This resulted in a solid database, which, in combination with the interdisciplinary theoretical framework, offered a rich description and understanding of communications occurring on online review platforms. Hybridization through the circulation of concepts and practices can be seen in a combination of several concepts and theories proposed in the literature review, practices in conducting participant observation, netnography, document analysis and interviews, and systematical and meticulous approaches to directed content analysis proposed in nursing literature. This interdisciplinary approach to building a theoretical framework and methodology resulted in a framework that is consistent with the ones found in the previous literature, yet enriched in so many ways; thus, it now presents as a complex and comprehensive perspective, from which future research on review platforms and similar social media channels could be observed from. Interdisciplinary approaches to research in tourism have the potential to open paths towards post-disciplinary approaches and provide a firm basis to deal with more complex problems, such as environmental changes and mobility crisis management (Munar et al., 2016, p. 346).

Such as how successful interdisciplinary research groups invest considerable time in managing differences and creating common ground (Oberg, 2009), from personal experience, I can prove that it also takes time as an interdisciplinary thesis writer to be self-reflective and consider one's epistemological stance, to cognitively process what was being written in the literature on a desired research topic, and to see which disciplines, theories, and methods would be most useful in conceptualizing and conducting the research. This is what Oberg (2009) describes as a sufficiently and coherently demarcated study, anchored in relevant literature with information collected in a reliable and efficient manner. In the case of my thesis, I got the chance to practically experience data collection and research strategies through several stages, devoting enough time and space to engage in both real-time, on-spot participative observations and those that took place in the online environment. Each stage has its own know-how that is supposed to be

acquired in order to ensure the collection of quality information for the study. As proposed by Oberg (2009), contemplating and discussing questions of assessment tools as part of the research process will develop self-aware learning, which is one the most challenging yet exciting and encouraging aspects of interdisciplinary research projects.

In the study by Okumus et al. (2018), emphasis was placed on courses, curricula and supervisor guidance as important requirements for students to adopt an interdisciplinary approach towards studying and doing research on tourism. Oberg (2009) also states that those who are able to create a climate that stimulates dialogue with the group have a greater chance of success in interdisciplinary projects. Following these views, the role of the thesis supervisor in assuring dialogue climate is crucial in the educational/pedagogical processes of writing an interdisciplinary thesis. Here, I provide a reflective account of my supervisor regarding the applications that assisted this process, based on which suggestions on how to improve interdisciplinary training in the tourism department may be derived:

I consider the transfer of knowledge and theoretical perspectives from different disciplines to tourism education curriculums at graduate level to be very beneficial. However, there are certain difficulties in its application. First of all, it is not possible to include a large number of courses for all the different disciplines that can inform the curricula of tourism graduate programs while ensuring that the professional formation in tourism education, tourism business administration formation, and ethical codes of the World Tourism Organization coexist in equal proportions. Second, in the case that tourism educators teach courses from different disciplines in the scope of graduate programs, there is the potential danger of shallowness and insufficiency in transferring necessary knowledge from the various disciplines. However, as a useful strategy to overcome these challenges, I praise the efforts of the Institute of Social Sciences, the executor of graduate programs at our university, for providing tourism graduate students with the opportunity to take courses from other scientific fields and disciplines. In this way, undergraduate tourism students have been allowed to continue with master and PhD programs by joining them together with programs of other disciplines—something that can be referred to as the expatriate-repatriate cycle. This allows them to learn about and apply different theoretical perspectives and methods, which will be of great support to them when writing their master and doctoral dissertations in tourism. Furthermore, in order to develop multidisciplinary, interdisciplinary and other disciplinary perspectives, I believe that faculties should accept graduate students from social sciences and natural sciences outside the field of tourism as well. Throughout my long teaching career, I have witnessed significant advantages and successes of students who pursue their PhD programs in tourism, but had previously completed undergraduate and graduate programs in other disciplines.

Another practice is to provide regular seminars for tourism graduate programs by academicians from different disciplines, allowing them to approach some tourism-related phenomena with different lenses. This can especially help graduate students in preparing scientific projects with their colleagues and scholars from different disciplines and in learning different theoretical perspectives by producing joint scientific publications. All these applications contribute to the methodological and theoretical advancement and deepening of tourism, for which debates regarding whether it is a science or an application field still continue. These educational and pedagogical approaches and applications also provide us, tourism academicians and educators, with the opportunity to develop our own understanding and experience of different disciplinary approaches to tourism—multi-, inter-, trans, and post-disciplinary.

There is a lack of homogenization and a standardized scientific community of tourism (Darbellay, 2016), but researchers interested in this field should think more towards openness, interaction, and integration, as this will push the limits of the field. Moreover, Tribe's (2010) recommendation that academicians should philosophically contemplate the meaning and purpose of tourism education and tourism's ontological foundations is also applicable to PhD candidates and fresh graduates. The rich knowledge of tourism epistemology that has been collected over the previous decades represents the broad common ground and shared traditions for seniors and new tourism scholars. Based on it, they can derive new interpretations regarding how knowledge can be produced in the tourism field. The linguistic approach proposed by Belhassen and Caton (2009) can be applied to knowledge development in tourism studies, but also to the literature related to disciplinary and knowledge production debates in tourism studies. My presentations of the PhD research process and results in this manner are my attempt to reflect on the complexity of conceptualizing and conducting tourism studies in an interdisciplinary spirit and how this can stimulate further research on certain topics. This reflective study may potentially be used as a reference in some future elaboration on tourism epistemological issues, as it provides interpretations of how to approach knowledge production in tourism from the perspective of a PhD student. In addition, a diverse range of reflexive standpoints of PhD students and degree holders is necessary so that we can better trace the development on tourism disciplinary-related issues and evaluate the theses, PhD courses, and overall curriculum.

Adopting an interdisciplinary approach to tourism research is by no means a fixed entity. It is rather the present state that may become part of the past when future trans- or post-disciplinary approaches develop. I realize how my previous educational and professional experiences gain new meaning after delving into tourism academia and embracing the multi- and interdisciplinary nature of its studies. This is where I find similarities with Pike's (2003) transition from "booster" to "holistic view" tourism scholar, as I acknowledge that we can make our past experiences meaningful for the future projects we intend to conduct. This "meaningful conjunction of future and past make possible present in which one's situation can appear as making specific sort of demand on one, as calling for some specific type of action" (Guignon, 2012, p. 103). In the context of the current study, this is a call for pursuing interdisciplinary research in tourism. Through immersion into new disciplines and learning and knowing through practice, tourism researchers may benefit from a variety of theoretical and methodological journeys. In this way, they will allow themselves to become better at describing emerging phenomena, predicting the consequences of the advocated and performed tourism development policies, analyzing tourism stakeholders–technology interactions, and understanding the needs and behavioral patterns of new generations of tourists, policy makers, tourism researchers, educators, and students.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Edina Ajanovic: Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Investigation, Methodology, Visualization, Writing – original draft. **Beykan Çizel:** Conceptualization, Methodology, Supervision, Validation, Writing – review & editing.

Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jhlste.2021.100310.

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